

FRENCH REVOLUTION



IN 1789, REVOLUTION BROKE OUT in France when people rose up against poverty and injustice. The French Revolution swept away the power of the monarchy and ended the traditional social order. When the revolution began, poverty was widespread, the king was unpopular, and people resented the clergy and nobility. Following the formation of the National Assembly, France was declared a republic, the king was executed, and, for a while, terror reigned. In 1799, Napoleon came to power, and the revolution ended.



Revolutionary Paris

The key events of the revolution occurred on the streets of Paris. Various political groups sprang up, such as the Jacobin Club, which relied on the Parisian *sans culottes* for support.

National Assembly

In 1788, France ran out of money, and King Louis XVI called the Estates General, representing clergy, nobility, and middle classes. The Third Estate formed a National Assembly, seized lands, and drew up a new constitution.

Rights of Man

The National Assembly issued the *Declaration of the Rights of Man and the Citizen*, stating that "Men are born and remain equal". Women's rights were not included, but the ideals of "liberty, equality, and fraternity" inspired everyone.



Storming of the Bastille

In 1789, angry demonstrators seized the Bastille, a prison that had been a symbol of oppression for many years. This act sparked a wave of rebellion. Outside Paris, peasants attacked the country houses of the nobility they hated.



Reign of Terror

By 1792, the revolution was under threat. There were food shortages, royalist uprisings in the countryside, and a threat by Prussia to invade and restore the monarchy. Extremists, known as Jacobins, grew in power, declaring a republic and executing the king in 1793. They set up the Committee of Public Safety, and a reign of terror began. Anyone suspected of being an enemy of the revolution was arrested and guillotined. Thousands died. By 1794, the leaders of the Committee were themselves executed, and the terror was over.

Revolutionaries

The revolutionaries were men and women from all social classes: lawyers, peasants, workers. Street revolutionaries were known as *sans culottes* (without breeches) because they wore striped trousers. Two rival revolutionary groups emerged: the Girondins and the more radical Jacobins.

Guillotine

Named after a French doctor, the guillotine consisted of a wooden frame, with a sharp blade mounted on it, which sliced off the victims' heads. This killing machine was quicker than previous methods of execution, and was, therefore, thought to be more humane.



Sharpened blade fell on victims' necks.

Robespierre

A lawyer by profession, Maximilien Robespierre (1758–94) was one of the leaders of the revolution. He headed the Jacobin Club, and, by 1793, was leader of the Committee of Public Safety that conducted the Reign of Terror. In 1794, he, too, went to the guillotine.



Marseillaise

From 1792, revolution spread outside French borders. A soldier composed the *Marseillaise* as a revolutionary marching song. Today, it is France's national anthem.



The bonnet rouge, or red bonnet, symbolized freedom. It looked like the cap worn by freed Roman slaves.

Coarse working blouse

White was the colour of the royal family.

Red and blue were the colours of Paris.

Striped trousers

Strong leather shoes

1788 France bankrupt. Louis XVI summons Estates General.

May 1789 Third Estate forms National Assembly.

Louis XVI



14 July, 1789 Paris mob storms the Bastille; French Revolution begins.

27 August, 1789 National Assembly issues *Rights of Man*.

October 1789 Women march to Versailles from Paris to demand bread.

1791 The French revolution inspires a slave rebellion in Haiti.

1792 National Assembly abolishes monarchy. France becomes a republic and goes to war with Austria and Prussia.

1793 Louis XVI executed. Counter-revolution breaks out. Revolutionary war spreads across Europe.

1793–4 Reign of Terror.

1795 The Directory, a more moderate board of governors, is formed and takes power.

1799 Napoleon overthrows Directory and takes power.

1798–99 Revolution inspires uprisings in Ireland.

FIND OUT MORE

AMERICAN REVOLUTION

EUROPE, HISTORY OF

FRANCE, HISTORY OF

GOVERNMENT AND POLITICS

NAPOLEONIC WARS